

Clerk: Increasing workload squeezing court staff in Arlington

by SCOTT McCAFFREY, Sun Gazette Newspapers
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Incoming Arlington School Board member Tannia Talento takes the oath of office from Clerk of the Circuit Court Paul Ferguson, as her father and husband look on, on Dec. 19, 2016.

Increasing amounts of paperwork – whether of the hard-copy or electronic variety – are putting the squeeze on the staff of Arlington’s clerk of the Circuit Court.

Clerk Paul Ferguson on March 27 told County Board members there has been a 12.2-percent increase in documents filed or recorded over the past year in his office, and the strains are starting to show.

“We are getting complaints from our line staff that the work is causing stress,” Ferguson said at a work session making the case for the \$3.45 million office budget proposed by County Manager Mark Schwartz.

Ferguson said the use of more technology – half of land-record filings are now done electronically, for instance – is helpful but only goes so far in reducing backlogs and easing the stress on personnel.

“The technology has allowed us to get to an acceptable level [of service],” said Ferguson, who was first elected in 2007. “Even though we’ve got the technology, we need staff.”

“We’re very lean,” Ferguson said of the office staffing. “We’re asking them to do what they can . . . [but if growth continues], we will be asking for more.”

County Board Chairman Christian Dorsey said that, in a tough year, he was pleased that the clerk’s office hadn’t come in with requests for significant increases to its 27-member staff.

“We appreciate that,” Dorsey said.

The clerk’s office is eliminating one position in courtroom technology, but will be adding a courtroom clerk to support the incoming fourth Circuit Court judge.

Funding for the clerk’s office is split between the state and local governments. Net tax revenue required to fund the office in Schwartz’s fiscal 2020 budget proposal is \$1.8 million, up 6 percent from the current fiscal year.

While technology can aid in reducing staff workload, it has a limited lifespan and will have to be updated and replaced eventually.

“In the near term, we’re looking like we’re in good shape,” Ferguson said in the budget presentation. “But I can’t make those absolute promises.”

A former County Board member himself, Ferguson is in his second eight-year term as clerk of the Circuit Court, which handles criminal and civil matters both in Arlington and the city of Falls Church.